Westbrook Planning Board

~ Planning Board Meeting ~

Date: Tuesday, April 7, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1180986441
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_04072026-994

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *This was a long meeting (nearly two hours) with an extensive Rock Row Phase 3 presentation; summarization necessarily condenses and selects. For complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

I. Roll Call & Announcements

Roll Call & Minutes [0:25]

Discussion Summary

Chair Larry McWilliams called the meeting to order. Roll call: five of nine seated members present (McWilliams, Lucas Schrage, Kevin Price, Jason Frazier, and Karen Axelson); Oriana Farnham, Robin Tannenbaum, Nancy Litrocapes, and Vice Chair John Turcotte absent.

Key Decisions

✓ Minutes of the February 3, 2026 meeting approved by roll call, 5–0.

Action Items

None.

Personnel Announcement — New City Planner [2:06]

Discussion Summary

Assistant City Administrator Jenny Franceschi announced that Rebecca Spitella has been appointed Director of Planning and Code Enforcement and will serve as the board's primary presenting city planner going forward, effective after this meeting. Franceschi thanked the board and the development community she has worked with over roughly the past decade.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

New Business

26-000106 — Conditional Use — 33 Elmwood Ave, Redeemer Church [3:08]

Discussion Summary

Pastor Joel Miller returned with the Place of Worship conditional use workshopped at the March 3 meeting. Two site improvements are planned to meet code: replacing the front entrance with a double door for improved egress capacity, and building out an approximately 18.5′×15′ room in the rear corner as a childcare/nursery space for Sunday services. No public comment, no staff concerns, no board discussion.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved unanimously by roll call, 5–0 (moved by Kevin Price, seconded by Lucas Schrage).

Action Items

None.

25-000758 — Site Plan, Subdivision & Conditional Use — 112 Pierce Street [6:46]

Discussion Summary

Dustin Roma (DM Roma Consulting Engineers, for applicant Craig Holman/Gopi LLC/Weld LLC) presented a revised plan following an earlier sketch-plan review and board site walk: the existing two-unit duplex near Pierce Street remains (with minor modifications for a new driveway), a new single-family home is added along the access drive, and a 10-unit multifamily building goes at the rear of the site — 11 new units total. Responding to earlier board feedback, the design now routes all multifamily units through a single front entrance with interior stairs to basement-level units, eliminating the wrap-around exterior entrances shown at the sketch-plan stage.

Several Mayberry Road-area residents spoke about longstanding and worsening drainage problems behind their homes, directly abutting the site (see the companion Point/Counterpoint write-up for the full exchange). City Planner Rebecca Spitella explained the board's jurisdiction is limited to ensuring the project's post-development runoff rate does not exceed its pre-development rate; the off-site drainage obstructions residents described sit on a neighboring private parcel and predate the City's current surface-drainage permitting process, so they are a private-property matter outside this project's or the City's authority to compel a fix. Chair McWilliams pressed the applicant team to proactively contact the affected neighboring property owners even though it falls outside the project's formal responsibility; the applicant agreed. Member Karen Axelson voted against, citing ongoing concern about cumulative drainage effects based on her own prior experience with a large nearby development.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 4–1 by roll call (McWilliams, Schrage, Price, and Frazier in favor; Axelson opposed), moved by Kevin Price, seconded by Lucas Schrage, incorporating the findings and conditions in the April 3, 2026 staff memo.

Action Items

None.

Point/Counterpoint — 112 Pierce St.: New Development vs. Pre-Existing Drainage

The neighbors' case

> *“That water will stay there for several weeks, if not months... My concern is that [the detention pond] is almost at the level of my backyard... I'm just thinking that my backyard will be saturated.”*

— Ratanachap Shafro, 34 Mayberry Road (public comment, showing a photo of current ponding in his backyard) [25:57]

Shafro, who is on a septic system rather than sewer, raised concern about potential impact to his leach field. Anna Robell, 24 Mayberry Road [30:16], read a letter into the record citing “engineering flaws or failures of the much smaller development behind their home” as a contributing cause, and urged preserving the hillside's large maple trees as a natural water buffer. Jim Donnelly, a 25-year resident of 24 Mayberry Road [32:42], corroborated a “substantial increase in water retention” over time, citing a neighbor's sump pump that “basically exploded” during a rain event after being capped off during a remodel. Elizabeth Bullett (118 Pierce St.) [34:36] separately raised concerns about the applicant's financial track record (citing 77 municipal tax liens recorded against the ownership entities since 1990, since cleared) and questioned why the project's in-lieu-of-open-space fee was calculated on 11 units rather than the property's eventual 13 total dwelling units.

Staff and applicant's response

[22:48] City Planner Rebecca Spitella explained the board's jurisdiction is limited to ensuring post-development runoff doesn't exceed pre-development rates; the drainage obstructions residents described sit on a neighboring private parcel at 34 Mayberry Road and are a private-property matter between those owners. Roma explained the engineering team identified two likely causes during their own investigation: a narrow, “perched” culvert and retaining-wall fill placed in a drainage ditch on the adjacent parcel, apparently during construction around 2019 — before the City's current surface-drainage permitting process existed, meaning no permit violation exists for staff to enforce against retroactively. On the fee question, Spitella clarified in-lieu fees apply only to newly created units (11), not units that already existed (the duplex's 2).

> *“There's enough elevation from one side of that adjacent site to where the water enters that that drainage should be able to be restored in a way that can actually help these folks. Someone just needs to make the effort to do it.”*

— Dustin Roma, project engineer [52:59]

Chair McWilliams pressed the applicant team to proactively reach out to the two affected neighboring property owners, even though it falls outside this project's formal responsibility; Roma agreed public review processes like this one are partly why such issues come to light. Member Lucas Schrage asked whether the new detention system might actually improve on current unmanaged conditions during spring thaw; Roma agreed it likely would, since frozen ground currently prevents infiltration entirely. Member Jason Frazier reviewed the detention pond's specific elevations and confirmed with staff that nearby catch basins were cleaned as part of a water-main project the prior summer. Member Karen Axelson asked whether the ponding area functions as a protected vernal pool (staff: no, it's an altered drainage ditch) and shared that a prior large development changed her own property's water conditions despite similar assurances, voicing ongoing concern about cumulative effects.

Workshop/Planner's Business — Rock Row Phase 3 Master Plan (No Vote)

[1:11:49] Josh Levy (Waterstone Properties Group/Dirigo Center Developers, LLC), civil engineer Wayne Morrill (Jones & Beach Engineers), and master planning architect David Boyce (Arrow Street, a 1984 Westbrook High

School graduate) presented a conceptual master plan for Rock Row's next phase, seeking board feedback ahead of individual site plan submissions for each building. No vote was requested — this was informational only.

Background & Phase 3 scope

[1:13:08] The developer purchased the roughly 100-acre former Blue Rock Quarry site from Pike Industries about eight and a half years ago, when it was already permitted for a 550,000-square-foot single-story shopping center; that plan was abandoned in favor of the mixed-use development seen today. Phase One (Market Basket, REI, Chick-fil-A, Starbucks, opened 2020) has drawn 19 million total visits, including 4.4 million last year and 960,000 unique customers; the healthcare campus has served roughly 150,000 patients since opening in 2025.

Phase 3 sits between the restored Nason's Brook and the rail line, bordered by Larrabee Road and the turnpike. The plan includes a 267-unit apartment building with an adjoining 7-story, 700-space parking garage topped with retail (the first component to be formally filed this week), 12 condo townhomes along the brook, loft office space over ground-floor retail, a small-footprint hotel, and an entertainment/recreation building. Zoning allows up to 85% building coverage; this plan approaches but doesn't reach that maximum. The applicant's goal is to begin vertical construction roughly a year from now, with retail openings by the end of 2027 and residential/hotel/office openings rolling into 2028. Each building component will return to the board individually for formal site plan review.

Point/Counterpoint — design philosophy

> *"This is an asset limited, income constrained community. This is a river city, it is a mill town... I would love to see the people that already live in this community be able to use Phase three... not pulling in people from other communities."*

— Member Lucas Schrage [1:33:53]

Schrage encouraged the developer to consider affordable or mixed-income housing given the project's scale, cited at roughly $600 million.

> *"I kind of counter that. I say go luxury. Go big or go home... Westbrook needs that... some luxury high-end."*

— Member Jason Frazier [1:37:11]

Frazier praised the development's coordination with Metro on bus access and encouraged further bike-lane connectivity to Portland. Member Kevin Price suggested the retail mix include more informal "third place" gathering spaces that don't require a purchase to use [1:46:11], and encouraged recruiting established local and regional businesses rather than relying solely on national chains. Member Karen Axelson, who recalled attending early community meetings about the project back in 2019, asked about plans for the flooded quarry pit; Josh Levy described an unresolved, still-evolving concept — stopping the rising water level before it reaches the surface to preserve a rock outcropping for potential outdoor movie nights or projected light shows, contingent on resolving wall-stability and safe public-access questions that remain unstudied in detail. He clarified that a proposed enclosed entertainment/conference venue and a long-discussed movie theater are both being considered for a later phase, not Phase 3. Chair McWilliams, who recalled being on the City Council when Rock Row was first proposed, praised the project's walkability and tree-planting plans.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked

names against the official Planning Board roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

Produced by Westbrook Currents — westbrookcurrents.com